Berkman siblings in conversation

Interviewer: **Thank you all for joining me here for this interview. It's great timing that you're all visiting and able to come together for this interview. I am currently conducting social research on Jewish identity and connectedness and the different ways that people understand their identity; how they enact it, how they regard themselves but also the role of critical Jewish experiences during upbringing. There are different things that people find meaningful or otherwise during their pre-18 years and I'm interested in your views on, first question, where you see yourselves now Jewishly and second question, what would be the role of some of those experiences in upbringing in shaping where you see yourself now.**

The difference in this methodology compared to other kinds of research, at least in the Jewish family research space, is that usually parents are asked about their children or individuals are asked about themselves. It's very unusual to have families in conversation or siblings in conversation. Often when parents speak they speak *on behalf* of rather than allowing young people to speak for themselves. That was the rationale behind this particular way of enquiring. Who'd like to go first and give us a basic background - how old you are, what life stage you're in, what you're doing at the moment and then Jewishly: how you describe yourselves. Tali, are you oldest?

Tali: I am, yeah.

Interviewer: **Do you want to start off? Where you see yourself now Jewishly, what life stage you're in, what you're up to.**

Tali: So I'm 31, I'm in early motherhood, living with my partner in country Victoria. I've chosen to live out of Melbourne for about eight years now and so the challenge has been how to engage still with Jewish community and how to do my own practices and to feel like I'm 'doing Jewish' in my life. So we do Shabbat Friday nights. But before the pandemic, I was probably going into Melbourne for Shabbat dinner plus or minus a couple of Shabbat service maybe once every month or two. Probably more frequently in terms of just Shabbat dinner but getting to Shul less frequently.

But I'll do my own little Kabbalat Shabbat thing if I'm by myself or I do candles and Havdalah Saturday night. I don't know, I mean previously I've gone through phases of like turning my phone off. I mean I try and have a 'low phone day' on a Saturday and just don't look at it very much. Festivals have dropped off the bandwagon a little bit since leaving school, I'd say, in general. That's a start.

Interviewer: **Living in the area that you're living, is that lifestyle? Is that professional?**

Tali: Yeah, it's both. I like living in more open space closer to nature. And also I was drawn to work opportunities outside Melbourne as well. So trained as a doctor, I found you get more hands-on experience not in the heart of Melbourne. So I've managed to find the balance of not being thrown in the deep end too much.

Interviewer: **Amir? I'm assuming, you're the middle sibling?**

Amir: Yeah, sure and hi everyone. Yeah so currently I'm living in Perth, 29 years old and I've been there for just over 18 months. I moved there for work and I'll probably move back to Melbourne in probably three months' time so it'll be a two-year stint. **I work for […] in a sustainability consulting area and am currently seconded to […] in their corporate relations team**. From a Jewish point of view this is without doubt the least-Jewish I've been in life, from an observance and practice point of view. And just thinking back since I moved there, I rarely do anything on a Friday night connected to Judaism. I went to Yom Kippur – not even, actually, I went to Rosh Hashana 12 months ago at the shul here and I've done a couple of dinners around major festivals but outside of that not a lot by way of practice or observance.

Still my closest friends there are Jewish. They were friends that I had before I moved to Perth, one that I went to school within Melbourne and one through [Progressive youth movement], the youth movement that we're involved in. Actually one of my housemates is – he went on Birthright – his mum's Jewish, his dad's not so we talk about Judaism from time to time. So I don't know, I guess the connection is - socially, I socialise with Jewish people still and then it comes up in conversation. I still feel very Jewish, like definitely I identify when it comes up in conversation with people that I meet where relevant and I probably even take a little bit more pride in it now than I did before. Still trying to work out why exactly that is, I think it's because it feels like a point of difference and people are interested. It's like an interesting element of someone's life or personality beyond "what do you do for work? What are your hobbies?". Yeah and maybe that's a maturity thing in this stage of life. But there's actually not a lot that I really do at the moment.

Interviewer: Do you think that the interest in the Jewish piece, is that Perth or is that the company you are working in? Where does the pride come from? You said that it seems to be a bit more present.

Amir: Yeah, I don't know. [Pauses] If there's such a thing as "minority syndrome", where like you look for things to identify in yourself that are different from everyone else. And being Jewish in Melbourne didn't feel like anything special, because we grew up in **the biggest bubble of Judaism** that one possibly could. **None of us went to non-Jewish schools for a day in our lives, so we were completely immersed in it**. It was just very normal, but here it certainly doesn't feel like it's a shared thing that you have with people in your life. So, we probably look for things like that to differentiate or find to define our identity sometimes by how you're different to people rather than what you have in common sometimes.

Interviewer: Gal?

Gal: Yeah so I'm the youngest, I'm 26 and I'm a law grad at […]. I think for me I'm probably similar to Amir in some respects, I think comparatively to where I was a few years ago Jewishly I'm definitely doing less and I would attribute that 100% to starting fulltime work, not anything to do with a lack of interest but a lack of time. Thinking about upbringing which was Progressive Jewish school, Progressive Shul, Progressive youth movement, only had Jewish friends, went to Israel, all that stuff. If I'm just comparing what that was to where I am now it's completely different but I don't feel any less connected just because I'm doing less, it feels like I'm just working my way through a different stage of life, doing Law, working in all of that.

Commented [User1]: 2. Disambiguating 'Searching' through Interactional Evidence
This theme captures the transition from conferred to agentic identity and distinguishes between "identity optimization" (refining stable choices) and "fundamental crisis".

Amir describes being "without doubt the least-Jewish I've been" in terms of practice, yet he simultaneously reports taking "more pride in it now" and feeling "very Jewish". This illustrates the **"searching while committed"** profile, where the individual is refining the meaning of their identity in a new geographical context (Perth) rather than experiencing a crisis of faith.

Commented [User2]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme captures identity through the participants' own metaphors and labels rather than pre-defined researcher categories.

Amir uses the term **"minority syndrome"** to explain his increased pride in his identity when living outside the Melbourne "bubble".

Amir describes their upbringing as **"the biggest bubble of Judaism"**, a metaphor the manuscript uses to illustrate the systemic "mesosystemic laboratory".

Commented [User3]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by showing how macro-level factors (community/school) are filtered through relational dynamics (family/birth order) to shape individual identity.

Amir maps his identity against the **macro-level** systemic context of the Melbourne "bubble," explaining how the lack of "otherness" in his upbringing shaped his initial view of Judaism as "very normal".

So in terms of what I do now our family still does Shabbat dinner every Friday night and that's still present in my life. My friends are predominantly Jewish. I live with housemates, one is Jewish, one isn't. I'm mildly active in [Jewish Humanist congregation] and on and off in [Progressive congregation]. I actually recently just started teaching a Bat-Mitzvah student again. So we, all three of us, were tutors during school of Bnei-Mitzva.

So I'm probably doing a little bit more now than I was a few months ago and I do attend a few events and all the High Holy days and all of that stuff but I think being in Melbourne I have more access to it and it's a lot more what I'm used to, compared to Tali in regional Victoria and Amir in Perth. **I'm still very much within my community** here. So I feel like I'm doing a fair bit but definitely not as much as I was and not as much as I would like to be doing but I do feel very connected and still **quite intellectually engaged** in Judaism. But at this point in time focusing a lot on work and other commitments I do.

Interviewer: **I'm curious when you said that all of you tutored for Bar- and Bat-Mitzvah, was that through any particular institution, synagogue or was that through a school? How did people find you? Do the Berkmans have a reputation? How does this work?**

Gal: Yeah, I like to think we have a bit of a – [laughs] no, I don't know.

It's through [Progressive congregation] so Mum and Dad are very involved in [Progressive congregation]. We all learnt trope and learnt how to tutor, so I think since we were about 15 we've been tutoring Bnei-Mitzvah students and because [Progressive congregation]'s quite a small-knit community and there aren't that many young people involved, we took on a few students through there and then also through [other Progressive congregation] – not sure if the others tutored with [other Progressive congregation] but I did. I think in the Progressive community it is quite small-knit – connected and because we were also involved in [Progressive school] and [Progressive youth movement] **we have the triple whammy going on**. Bit of a foot in the door so people through [Progressive youth movement] or through [other Progressive congregation] or [Progressive congregation] or whatever had access to us and people that might be interested to having a tutor, I suppose and [Progressive school] as well.

So that's how it started but I would say the main point for tutoring would have been [Progressive congregation] to start and then branched out from there.

Interviewer: **If I'm understanding this correctly, you guys are a bit of a rarity; there aren't that many people like you who have the literacy, who are able to teach and that you're known in those three strands of your communal engagement. Can you think of somewhere in upbringing, in life pre-18 that might have inspired that? That might have – people regarded you, they came to you, they sought you out – where perhaps others may not have had those skills or that determination to give back?**

Amir: I can jump in. I'm not sure it'll sound as inspiring or special, but I think quite simply we all spoke Hebrew, we've all played music growing up, and when Mum and Dad probably put to Tali like if she learns she can tutor and that became a really normal thing for Gal and myself to see and look up to and go "we'll do the same thing". So it was like "you know Hebrew well enough, you're spending time in synagogue, you'll do your Bar-Mitzvah, it's not too much of an effort to then just go and show someone else how to do that."

Commented [User4]: 2. Disambiguating 'Searching' through Interactional Evidence
This theme captures the transition from conferred to agentic identity and distinguishes between "identity optimization" (refining stable choices) and "fundamental crisis".

Gal describes a reduction in Jewish activity due to full-time work but explicitly states, "I don't feel any less connected... it feels like I'm just working my way through a different stage of life". His endorsement of a strong connection while "doing less" serves as qualitative evidence of **identity optimization** during a life-stage transition.

Commented [User5]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme captures identity through the participants' own metaphors and labels rather than pre-defined researcher categories.

Gal describes him as **"quite intellectually engaged"** in Judaism, a specific content-descriptor that differentiates his connection from purely ritualistic observance.

Commented [User6]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme captures identity through the participants' own metaphors and labels rather than pre-defined researcher categories.

Gal uses the phrase **"triple whammy"** to describe the overlapping influence of their school, synagogue, and youth movement, illustrating how multiple informants co-construct the "substantive meaning" of their communal identity.

Commented [User7]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by showing how macro-level factors (community/school) are filtered through relational dynamics (family/birth order) to shape individual identity.

Amir explicitly references **birth-order role-modelling**, noting that because their older sister Tali tutored, it "became a really normal thing for Gal and myself to see and look up to". This demonstrates how identity formation is **filtered through the family microsystem**.

And we probably thought that's an easy way to earn $25 an hour [laughs] rather than having to go and be a checkout person at a supermarket. So I think we already had those skills just through spending time at [Progressive congregation], or doing Hebrew through school and no doubt every point in that Mum and Dad were encouraging, encouraging us or guiding us in that, without ever saying "this is what you have to do". The platform was there for us to just walk straight into.

Tali: I guess through [Progressive youth movement] as well – did you mention that, Amir?

Amir: No, I didn't.

Tali: I don't know, you got to know people, people got to know you through a youth movement as well, so they might say "do you want to teach our kid?" or whatever. I taught a bit through [other Progressive congregation] as well if families asked that or I think I just signed up through them at one point as well. Anyway, yeah.

Interviewer: I'm curious. The Jewish community Gen17 report said that when it came to reading, writing, speaking Hebrew, only a very, very small proportion of people said that they had a very high level of literacy. And that's across the denominations and regardless of however many years that people were at Jewish day schools. Where did your Hebrew come from?

Gal: Obviously school was where we learnt basics, but I think our interest in pursuing it beyond primary school and actually choosing to do it in high school – we all did VCE Hebrew, I think we all did Tertiary Hebrew – is that right, guys? We're not very diverse. [Laughs] And I think that was at least for me partly a connection to my Hebrew teachers, 100% wanting to have access to Hebrew and knowing that I would want that beyond school. I think the other thing was Mum and Dad were pretty – they were supportive but not pressuring in the slightest and I think for some reason we saw the value in doing Hebrew when a lot of people didn't really see that. We had a very small cohort of VCE Hebrew students at [Progressive school].

I actually think there was another event that helped and that was – you know the Zionist program that schools runs where they get people from Israel to come out? We used to host a lot of those madrichim who came out, and we did a lot of hosting in general but a lot of it, 80% of the hosting that we did would have been madrichim on the Zionist programs so we actually felt that sort of connection with madrichim through school and practised our Hebrew with them. We also have family and very close friends in Israel and so we had connection that I think a lot of people in terms of their literacy don't have a personal connection and a personal "in" to Hebrew and all these other things that we felt were a bit more interested in maintaining the literacy so that we could maintain the personal connections as well a little bit.

Interviewer: Are your parents Israeli? You said you've got family in Israel?

Gal: No, just distant relatives. They're not Israeli. We've got friends but actually our friends are Australian so they speak English. I think just interested in it like we really grew up very Jewishly. From the minute we were born we were going to [Progressive congregation] and running around and having Shabbat dinner and listening to Israeli tapes and videos. **Our parents sang to us in Hebrew, our**

Commented [User8]: 1. Real-Time Verification and Narrative Repair
This theme identifies "interactional action units" where siblings act as "truth-checkers" to corroborate, challenge, or expand upon individual narratives.

Amir begins explaining how the siblings became Bnei-Mitzvah tutors, attributing it to their skills in Hebrew and music. Tali immediately intervenes with a **repair sequence**, asking, "I guess through [Progressive youth movement] as well – did you mention that, Amir?". Amir admits he had not, and Tali provides the additional communal context. This illustrates siblings acting as **relational interlocutors** who force the clarification of narratives.

lullabies were in Hebrew. They loved it and they felt very connected. They also both went on Shnat, they felt very connected and I think that connection, because it started at such a young age we chose to pursue literacy and increase our Hebrew literacy.

Amir: Can I add one more thing? And, [interviewer], I suspect you'll have a problem with people in this interview.

Interviewer: We love that in interviewing.

Amir: But I think with the Bar-Mitzvah tutoring I also just realised because Mum and Dad have stayed involved, it feels like a nice thing to do in the context of our family, to stay involved as well. I think when Mum and Dad ask us to do things for Shul, whether it's now layning on Yom Kippur or playing guitar at something, I feel like it's a nice thing to do for them to say 'yes' and to be involved. It's not that I'm not enjoying doing that, but clearly I haven't been choosing to do that when I'm not around them in Perth now. So I feel like it's doing a nice thing for them and it pleases them and I get a kick out of pleasing them. Whenever they say "oh here's a student" – because they're so involved, I know how much time it takes up for Mum to play the role that she does in [Progressive congregation], she's very involved across a lot of aspects of that life.

Interviewer: What's her role?

Amir: She sings as the cantor, she's also involved in organising when a lot of the yamim noraim come around, all the service leading and then a lot of the cultural aspects of the Shul. Often if there's like a Purim event she'll be there early and help with the activities the kids are doing and probably heaps of other stuff.

Gal: She also used to do – I don't know, guys, if you remember this like when we were in primary school before [Progressive school] had a proper Jewish music program, she would come in to our grade 1 and 2 classes and teach the class Jewish music and play the guitar and all that stuff.

Interviewer: Powerhouse mum! Sounds nice.

Gal: She really is.

Tali: While we're on [the subject of] mum, she taught Bar-Mitzvah as well through [Progressive congregation] and so she's got a whole lot of Jewish books anyway, But if ever we had questions for planning a [Progressive youth movement] pe'ulah or needing a resource for a Bar-Mitzvah class or something it was always to pick Mum's brain or she'd direct us to which book of commentary to look at. I guess just having engaging conversations at home as well was helpful.

Interviewer: Sounds nice. You were saying that there was an intimate Hebrew class – I understand that across the Jewish schooling, there's only a tiny proportion that go ahead and do Hebrew. Did you all go on a gap year?

Gal: Yeah, we all went on [Progressive youth movement] shnat.

Interviewer: Can you tell me a bit about the gap year in terms of what kind of Israel experience you had? You're giving me this incredible opportunity to speak to you, to discover what might be typical or perhaps unique about

Commented [User9]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by showing how macro-level factors (community/school) are filtered through relational dynamics (family/birth order) to shape individual identity.

Gal connects **relational/micro** influences (parents singing Hebrew lullabies) to her **individual-level** decision to pursue Hebrew literacy at a tertiary level, illustrating the "ripple effect" of family ritual on personal achievement.

your family or a Progressive perspective on Israel. Can you share what that experience in Israel was like?

Amir: Gal, why don't you go first because you probably remember it the best out of all of us?

Gal: I'm going to say yeah, Tali could go first! She went first!

Tali: So you've probably heard from others about the Machon experience?

Interviewer: Yes.

Tali: So [Progressive youth movement] offered two gap-year programs, either Machon or […]. […] was living in a flat in Jerusalem for four months, none of us did that and it was a purely [Progressive youth movement]-focused program: Reform Judaism, Reform Zionism-heavy. I guess all of us having been to [Progressive school] – I don't know, maybe I can't speak for the others but certainly for me, having been to [Progressive school] I was quite keen to meet people outside that world during Machon. Then in the middle of the year there was two months of volunteering, so I was down in Be'er-Sheva working in a Bedouin community and also did a Noah Telem camp, which I think we might have all done.

Interviewer: What's Noah Telem?

Tali: It's the equivalent of [Progressive youth movement] in Israel, it's the Reform movement. Then the end of the year there was three months of either Kibbutz […] or Kibbutz […] which are the two Reform kibbutzim. We were all in […] and I don't know if you know much about those two kibbutzim –

Interviewer: I don't.

Tali: - but […] is older, […] is younger and typically I guess the people there are a bit more passionate about Reform Judaism, and about particularly environmentalism and social justice and permaculture and they have a little ecovillage thing and that sort of stuff. So yeah, I don't know, that's a bit of an outline, I guess, of the Shnat year.

Interviewer: Is that something that continues to have some kind of relevance? Was there something about that experience that informs your current self-concept?

Tali: Yeah, I mean mainly I would say that I met some really close friends on Machon and that they are friends that I call up with Jewish questions to chat through stuff with people that I met on Machon.

Interviewer: Did that feel like an *Israel* experience? Was that a *Progressive* experience? The reason why I say this is that when I spoke to a Hasidic family, the fact that they were in Israel wasn't so salient to them; it was about the people they met there and the reinforcement of their particular interpretation of Judaism. With the Modern Orthodox family that I spoke to, the fact that it was Israel was absolutely *critical* to their experiences of Judaism there. Ditto the Humanists; there was something very bound up in Israel in their experience. Progressive-Zionism: which of those do you think were or continue to be salient? Does that make sense?

Tali: I think it was critical that the program was in Israel. Yeah, I mean that was an amazing year living the whole Jewish calendar in Israel and other aspects of Israeli culture that are less religious, I suppose. I don't know, I mean there were a couple of years when I got back and there were a few of us that half had in the back of our heads that we would make aliya. But I feel like that Israel experience was really key at that time of my life in terms of running a youth movement and having done that as a Jewish adult, but Israel definitely plays less of a part of my Jewish existence nowadays.

Interviewer: Gal? Amir? What do you think? Is there something there that's similar, different?

Amir: Yeah, I think very similar so we all had similar experience there. Probably went into it in a similar mindset but yeah, I mean I think it was critical it was in Israel, really nice memories now, something that continues to connect – and will forever, really – us with a certain of group of people that we've got that year in common with. I think it was important for our time in [Progressive youth movement] afterwards to have had the on-the-ground experience and be able to talk to what it's like to speak with Israelis, meet Israelis. You get a much better understanding of the history, of the culture, the religion, the dynamic with other religions and other peoples there. I think it also was a year where we thought a lot about where Progressive Judaism – well I'll talk for myself – where Progressive Judaism does fit within the streams of other Judaism and it probably reinforce a lot of values that I went into the year with but it was a time when we were really, really engaged.

I mean **you can't really separate Israel from Judaism today**. For some people Israel's not a part of their life, Judaism's everything and probably in Israel it can probably be the opposite but I think from a generalised point of view they're pretty inseparable and I think having had that year there is just another element of why – just **helps complete the story of our identity** of both we have had the Jewish upbringing and we've also got to experience Israel in a very personal level. You can think memories and places and people come to mind in virtually every corner of the country so it enriches the way that I feel about Judaism as well.

Interviewer: I had one particular person who a few weeks ago said to me that she felt in Melbourne that her particular interpretation of Judaism, the denomination with which she was raised was one plate and going to Israel gave her a smorgasbord so there was a bit more variation and granulation in what could be and it allowed her to come back and integrate some of the things that she had from home with other things she'd seen there. So it was an interesting idea simply because the population was larger there so there was more diversity which I thought was interesting. Tali, did you meet people there that you continue to have relationships with or friendships with?

Amir: Yeah. Probably drifted from a few of the people on Machon it's now 10 years for us since we were there but yeah, I do and I think with [Progressive youth movement] as well there were some people who were very close during that year and that helped hold the friendship strong to this point in time.

Interviewer: Gal?

Gal: Yeah, I think broadly similar. Israel was definitely an integral part and also I think the Progressive community in Israel is quite different to the Progressive community here so that was important. In terms of Progressive Zionism I think in Australia it's really hard to understand what that is until you go to Israel and being on Shnat because progressive Zionism is a pillar of [Progressive youth movement] and no-one knew what it was. Going to Israel and experience with Progressive Zionism and Progressive Judaism there was completely integral to us being able to run a Progressive Zionist youth movement in Australia. And we all went on to take leadership roles within [Progressive youth movement], so I think that was definitely absolutely crucial that we got that learning and engagement in Israel with Progressive Zionism. Then in terms of bringing that back it largely manifested in [Progressive youth movement] and being able to educate based on our experience in Israel and I think without doing Shnat in Israel – obviously now we have options within [Progressive youth movement] about getting the education without going to Israel, without going on Shnat but at the time for us it was basically the education came from Shnat in Israel and learning and getting that educational base there. So yeah, that was definitely crucial.

I do still have I would say most of my friends, 90% at last, would be Shnat-related. I'm still very much involved in my Shnat group, friendship groups and also very connected still to the Israeli friends that I met over there. I think also just going back to our earlier conversation about Hebrew literacy, I think for some reason, and probably to do with Mum and Dad and also the millions of Zionist madrichim and shlichim that we formed personal connections with in high school, I think we saw **Hebrew as an opportunity to actually open doors**. I think a lot of other people just saw it as a burden and we actually experienced that in Israel like being able to lead Noa Telem for Israeli [Progressive youth movement] camps for Israelis leading in Hebrew.

That was an option that was available to me and no-one else in my Shnat group basically I had the level. I think we somehow listened to the advice in high school that said "Hebrew will open doors for you" and we took that on and that was really an open – so in terms of our Shnat-Israel experience, having the Hebrew I think was also a really – well having the Hebrew was another reason why Israel was important for us in terms of immersion and integration.

Interviewer: Some people can find a story or a memory of something from their upbringing or young adulthood that really informs how they're living now Jewishly. Did you experience a difference in Progressive Zionism in Israel that you found was surprising compared to the way you'd experienced Progressive Zionism here in Melbourne? Were there people who were from other countries that suggested any differences?

Amir: Yes, it's a really interesting question and I don't think I've got a good answer because it's not something that I think I've really reflected on so much in the past, so apologies in advance. But I think a lot of the Zionists that we met in Israel were people who had made aliyah from the UK and the US and some from Australia as well. Then we met the kids who'd grown up there and spoke English with a British accent or a US accent. So the generation that we were really engaging with, the kids that were born there as a result of their parents moving, they to me felt Israeli, Israelis really shared values. Then we were coming at it from like we've got common values and some of the religion but we don't have as much – the understanding or the appreciation for what it's like to be a Progressive Jew in Israel. [Pauses] I thought that was really inarticulate.

[Pauses] I guess I'm trying to say is like they had all taken it one step further and felt more Israeli – I feel like I'm not making sense at all. Someone else can talk. Sorry.

Interviewer: **Gal?**

Gal: Okay, I'll have a go. In Israel you have a very strong Progressive community as in people who made aliyah like British, American, whatever. And then the Israeli Progressive community like people who were born in Israel, I think they have a type of Progressive Judaism and Progressive Zionism that is much more focused on tikkun olam, social action and stuff. I think in Australia, probably also England and America, our Progressive Judaism and Progressive Zionism to me, and I'm just saying this like my personal experience, feels very based in ritual and heavy on the Judaism in terms of ritual-based traditional Judaism and tweaking that to make it relevant. The difference that I noticed in Israel was that people were – their manifestation of Progressive Judaism felt a lot more like tikkun olam – social justice stuff. It was very action-based. I think here it's still very religious feeling. That was my impression. I think it just depends like sometimes I feel like our Progressive community here feels a little bit influenced by America in the way that America does Progressive Judaism a little bit and Israel just felt quite different.

Interviewer: **I had a wonderful conversation with John Levi about a year or two ago. He was saying that the Progressive movement in Melbourne was very British Progressive Judaism-influenced, that was imported and then made Australian rather than it being an American Progressive. His understanding was it was much more traditional in a sense than his experience of American Progressive which I thought was interesting.**

Just to finish off, an anecdote, an image, a memory, something from upbringing that might give insight into where you see yourself now Jewishly?

Tali: I think we were always encouraged to make our own decisions and I mean that's a pillar of Reform Judaism is around informed decision-making which is really part of a lot of streams. But really when we were studying for our Bar-Mitzvahs, Mum would say "if you come up with a good argument as to why you don't want to keep kosher, we'll listen to that and you can potentially act on that". I think that was really open-minded compared to a lot of families.

I've just been reflecting on your earlier question about what of that Israel experience is still relevant and I think it was the first time that I'd gone to a – the same as what your person said about the smorgasbord – it was the first time I'd gone to a whole lot of different Shuls. There's so many different expressions of Judaism in Israel and also living with people who had been to Yavneh, Scopus, had not been to a Jewish school and debating with them about my practice and it helps understand where you sit when you debate with other people that but it also potentially broadens your mind and changes what you do from then on.

I did a lot of [Progressive congregation] stuff growing up and now there's three or four Shuls that I'm interested in or that I feel like have influenced the way that I do Judaism now, in Israel and in Australia. I think being brought up with that encouragement of being open-minded and then also being given an opportunity to experience such a vast array of ways of doing it really allowed me to take

bits from different things and piece together something that I honestly – I wouldn't really call myself a strong Progressive Jew at the moment, like that term doesn't really sit completely with me, because I feel like there are other influences that I really relate to as well. Does that answer your question?

Commented [User10]: 2. Disambiguating 'Searching' through Interactional Evidence
This theme captures the transition from conferred to agentic identity and distinguishes between "identity optimization" (refining stable choices) and "fundamental crisis".

Tali discusses the "informed decision-making" modeled by her parents and how experiencing a "smorgasbord" of Judaism in Israel broadened her mind. She notes she wouldn't call herself a "strong Progressive Jew" because she relates to other influences, demonstrating an **agentic identity construction** that moves beyond parental labels while maintaining a stable core.

Interviewer: **Yes. It does seem to be. A lot of people did say that being in Melbourne meant that it was less scandalous to crosspollinate, that in other larger communities, where perhaps division is just easier or just culturally normative, there's less border crossing. It seems so much more natural and normal to have those borrowings in Melbourne. I think we are tribal, unfortunately, but it seems less scandalous to -**

Tali: I think in terms of my own experience like that was modelled to me really for the first time in Israel where you go along to a Friday night – I can't remember what the Reform shul in Jerusalem's called –

Amir: Navah Tehila.

Tali: No. Anyway they had this Reconstructionist thing that was once a month based at the Reform thing so they needed to have people that were sometimes at the Reform normal thing and then they'd be at the Reconstructionist thing and then if that wasn't on or the next day, Saturday, they'd be at the Shira Chadasha version. It was like oh you don't have to lock yourself into one way of doing it.

Interviewer: **That can be enriching. A, you're choosing and that very active choosing is already powerful but then there's also the blending of the bits that appeal so that's really powerful too.**

Amir: Was it Kol Haneshama, Tali?

Tali: Yeah.

Interviewer: **Amir, a memory, an experience, a reflection, something from pre-18 that you think in some way indicates or shapes what you see yourself as?**

Amir: Yeah so I don't know, it's hard to pick out a single thing but I think there are pretty clearly three pillars and one is the [Progressive youth movement] experience. And then there's the school experience and then the family experience and probably the Shul experience so there's four and they all tie together. I think the connection to Israelis was really important through having as Gal mentioned earlier like the madrichim come and stay at our house. That helped drive a really fun connection to Israeli people because they were young and they took an interest in us. I think also with that year as well, just another thought that's come to mind, spending a year in Israel, I think it's given me a lot more confidence in other areas of my life since then too in terms of going into a one-year commitment to be away from home with lots of new people really predominantly around the Machon, that was four months with people from other youth movements. Since that time I think I've had a lot more confidence to throw myself into new things and I know that I'm going to make friends with people who I wasn't previously friends with. And yeah like the sense of independence you get from living away from home and managing really well has I think held me in good stead since that point in time.

I echo what Tali said about the informed decision-making and how that sort of fed through our upbringing as a way of thinking and also critical thinking. We

used to talk about the parshat hashavua on a Saturday lunch like after being in Shul with Mum and Dad and I think it encouraged us to take an interest in stories, in complexity, because all the stories have got a lot of drama in them and a lot of interesting ideas in them. I think their encouragement of us to think about that and dissect them and form views on what's right and wrong has driven an interest in that across all different topics. I'd be very, very interested in having discussions about Buddhism or, I don't know, the US election. I know that's not unique and a lot of people are interested in a lot of different things, but I think there's something in being interested in religion which a lot of us really like having good in-depth conversations where we break things apart and form views and – I don't know, consider philosophy. So that has come from a core of Judaism but now starting to filter out into other areas of my life, I'm guessing our lives across Tali and Gal as well.

So I think Israel was – like that Shnat year would be top of the list even though I've said there's nothing that really properly stands out – that's also post-18 but that was a very significant experience. I do think the Hebrew has been important and the music so all the songs that Mum and Dad used to sing to us and doing havdalah at home. I feel like – and I know I'm rambling here – but I feel like having the knowledge of more of the religious side of Judaism compared with a lot of our other friends who went to [Progressive school] has also enriched or made me feel more confident or more of an authority even though I'm not at all, but I like the fact that I do know what happens in a shul service even though I'm not particularly religious, really.

But I love being able to talk to that or share knowledge about that or just know that I can layn from the Torah, feels like a skill and it's knowledge that I'm really glad that I have and I think enriches my sense of Judaism. That is not widespread across our friendship groups and that has obviously come from growing up like being taken to shul by Mum and Dad and somehow them managing to make it like a fun or okay experience for us, where a lot of people hate going to shul and find it super-boring. I don't know how Mum and Dad did it but somehow they managed for it to be like a positive experience for us growing up. I love the fact that I've got that as part of my life now.

Interviewer: **Two impressions, Amir. One of them is an at-homeness in synagogue which cross-denomination seems hard to nail. And the other one, if I reflect on a lot of the British research I've seen, the average family does not have a meal together even on a weekly basis. So what you're talking about which may have begun as an opportunity to engage in the parashah, extending that across a wide range of topics, was still a chance to engage in topics with family, something that I think is quite special about Melbourne. The average American Jew leaves home at 18, goes off to college and then chases degrees across the States, might partner with someone somewhere else and ongoing intimate relationship with parents isn't an assumption that you can make about the majority of American young people. Yet** Tali**, after you finished school and gap-year, did you spend – I mean for medicine you would have been in Melbourne, yes?**

Tali: No so I did a biomedical degree at Melbourne Uni and I got into postgrad medicine at Monash which was their Gippsland campus, so that's when I moved out -

Interviewer: **But even for those undergraduate years, the fact that from what I can see the average Jewish young adult in Melbourne, regardless of**

denomination, for the first few years of young adulthood seems to be living within driving distance of parents. And that's something mind-blowing to Americans, they're like "but why don't they go to college?", I'm like "because they've got really good universities really close to home, why would you travel?" – no offence to Perth but "why would you go to Perth when you could do a degree in Melbourne?", you know what I mean? It's something that perhaps even – and this might sound radical to developmental psychologists but it might actually extend that opportunity not for influence but intimacy and interaction with parents much longer than is the case for Jews growing up in different countries which is a really interesting idea.

Gal, any memories, any reflections on growing up? Any particular incidents that you can think of that for you is meaningful in terms of where you are now?

Gal: Yeah, heaps but I think the ones that stand out, my first bnei-mitzvah student so I think that was probably at a time where I mean obviously going through – we all had very involved bnei-mitzvah years and were told that that it's our year and take autonomy over it and all of that. I think being able to teach. The first time I taught must have been about 15, I think. That was my first instance of "**Judaism is something that I can educate on and something that I can use to form connections with others and to enrich my own identity**" and I had that experience at quite a young age comparatively to other people who might not have had that experience later. But being 15 I think I was still quite young to be able to – we were all doing the same thing – to be able to feel like Judaism was something that I could take ownership over and use in a way that spoke to me and was really empowering. That's probably my first memory.

Then the other ones, I think Amir mentioned some of them but definitely Mum and Dad singing to us in Hebrew at a young age, that's a very strong memory for me so falling asleep to Hebrew songs. The other one would be the hosting, I think bringing Israelis into our home made a huge difference because it wasn't just we were having – a lot of people had great experiences with madrichim and were really engaged with them outside of the home so at school, youth movements. But bringing them in and having them as part of our lives inside the house and also that brought Mum and Dad in. **Mum and Dad were part of that experience** as the three of us were, that experience with those Israelis and it happened repeatedly year after year. I think that actually was the really important experience and a really strong memory for me as well.

It also meant that when I was too young like Tali and Amir were already – had the experience with the Zionist madrichim in high school and I was doing primary school, but in primary school I was having a similar experience to what they were having in a sense. So I think for me being the youngest and seeing Tali and Amir having those experiences in the home brought me into it at a much younger age. Seeing Mum and Dad engage with that as well, for me being the baby it felt like "this is a family experience". This is not something that Tali and Amir being the older ones get outside of the home.

So that would probably be my top three and I think, I just want to add something you were saying before especially about the Hebrew, it wasn't just being exposed to it in a positive way that helped, we really enjoyed it like we really loved it and I actually think that had a lot to do with the school. We had really strong connection with but I think also maybe we could learn Hebrew and other

Commented [User11]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by showing how macro-level factors (community/school) are filtered through relational dynamics (family/birth order) to shape individual identity.

Gal describes the family's practice of hosting Zionist *madrichim* (youth leaders). She notes that because she was the "baby" of the family, she was exposed to these **systemic/macro** influences at a much younger age than her siblings, making it a "family experience" rather than an individual one.

people didn't, because we liked it, it was enjoyable. Amir We were thrown into the deep end in terms of Judaism is a strong part of your life in an educational, literature, intellectual base way, often discussing Jewish themes and ideas as a family. So all those memories I think combine probably, made me feel really empowered to connect to Judaism and make it a big part of my life.

Tali: I was just going to say speaking of like you having experiences earlier than you would have otherwise because we had the madrichim, I remember because Mum was a medic on [Progressive youth movement] camps so we would go along to [Progressive youth movement] camps before we were in grade 3, which is when it started. We'd be much younger, getting brought along to these camps and so we'd come home singing all the songs and wearing the t-shirts. So we were already [Progressive youth movement] babies well before [Progressive youth movement] days as well.

I'm just going to say in terms of being sung Hebrew songs like Hebrew songs are the only ones I end up singing to [her baby], they're the ones that come naturally.

Amir: I'd also really emphasise the role of [Progressive youth movement] because I think that brought together both Judaism and made it really fun because we were in a really good social environment and so many of my friends from school did go to [Progressive youth movement] and we had a huge year which was not standard, actually but I think we all it's fair to say had a really good social experience at [Progressive youth movement] so that was just a fun environment to be in. It was heavily Jewish, it was heavily Israel-oriented. It also gave us opportunities to own it so like I'm sure you know this very well like you're leading peulot, you're coming up with the ideas, you're trying to encourage discussion around Jewish themes. The way [Progressive youth movement] does it like we cover a broad spectrum of social justice, environment so there's the connection to Israel, what does progressive Judaism mean in the world today? Just a lot of different topics that I think really related to well and then there's the musical element and we're leading services and then there's Israel.

It just brought everything together really well in a really fun environment where we weren't being told what to do like we were owning it, taking responsibility, leading kids, educating. And I think that drove a lot of the really positive experience that I've had with Judaism and Israel in life beyond just – had I gone to a non-Jewish school, I'd have probably the same fantastic friends today. The fact that they're not Jewish may make a little bit of a difference, but [Progressive youth movement], you were doing something beyond just what might have happened otherwise like this was extracurricular. It was **a lifestyle without being cultish** and I think that was really formative and important for my positive association with my Jewish identity.

Gal: I've thought of one more memory.

Interviewer: Please.

Gal: There was a time, I must have been about 10, 11, 12 when Tali and Amir were already going to [Progressive youth movement] camp – as Tali said I probably went on my first [Progressive youth movement] camp when I was two! So Tali and Amir were already going to [Progressive youth movement] and I didn't have a good social group in [Progressive youth movement]. I went to Habo for a few years and a lot of my [Progressive school] friends went to Habo so probably

Commented [User12]: 1. Real-Time Verification and Narrative Repair
This theme identifies "interactional action units" where siblings act as "truth-checkers" to corroborate, challenge, or expand upon individual narratives.

Following Gal's reflection on their upbringing, Tali provides **meta-commentary** to add a detail Gal omitted: that their mother was a medic on youth movement camps. Tali uses this to explain why they were "[Progressive youth movement] babies" well before they were of age, verifying the depth of the family's institutional immersion.

Commented [User13]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme captures identity through the participants' own metaphors and labels rather than pre-defined researcher categories.

Amir describes their Jewish involvement as a **"lifestyle without being cultish"**, a participant-generated term capturing the balance between high commitment and secular integration.

three or four camps I went to Habo. I actually think in that time – it's a strong memory for me because talking about the family like we felt like such a strong, connected, Progressive family and here I was going to Habo which was different. Firstly what comes to mind is that mum and dad were super-supportive, they couldn't care less if I went to Habo and I personally – it felt like a difference to me that I – Tali and Amir hadn't gone to Habo at all, Mum and Dad hadn't gone to Habo at all and I was going because my friends were going. Then my decision to come back to [Progressive youth movement] in Year 9 really felt intentional in the sense that I was reconnecting with my roots and my family, and I think a lot of that had to do with the upbringing that was so – it was a whole family experience.

It wasn't like Mum and Dad saying "We're going to send our kids outside the house for education because we support it", it was "We're going to bring their education inside because we want to be a part of it and we want to support that from the inside". I feel very lucky that they made that decision, and I think a lot of families didn't. And also that Mum and Dad had the knowledge and the skill to be able to facilitate that. I think a lot of parents don't have the Hebrew or don't have the connection or don't have the personal experience themselves, and it's no fault of theirs, but we were really lucky that Mum and Dad had the ability and the resources to bring Judaism and Israel back into the home. Progressive Judaism's such that when I decided to go back to [Progressive youth movement] after a few years at Habo I really felt like I was reconnecting to where I wanted to be. So as a young teenager that was also a really unique experience and memory that I have in terms of Progressive life.

Interviewer: **Intentionality is a very powerful thing.**

Such a powerful idea that sometimes Gal, you spoke about teaching and feeling empowered, that sometimes when we have to explain it to someone else, in the process we explain it to ourselves and sometimes that can be quite a powerful experience.

Thank you all. I really, really appreciate your time.

END OF TRANSCRIPT